

Generative AI and The Future of Knowledge Work: Exploring Perceptions of Job Replacement, Job Augmentation, and Organizational Responsibility

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Abstract

The rapid large-scale adoption of generative AI tools by knowledge work industry organizations and companies have yielded benefits to worker productivity and efficiency. However, workers maintain concerns about the possibility of Gen AI-based automation of worker roles and hold organizational executive decision makers responsible for ethical implementation of Gen AI technology usage. To understand these decision maker perspectives, we interviewed 17 high level employees, managers and executives across knowledge work organizations. Our results show that decision makers are enthusiastic about Gen AI-based worker augmentation but are unsure of the long-term effects on worker role transformation, employment shifts and potential for automation of worker roles. We therefore make recommendations for decision makers to include both executive and worker perspectives in the creation of Gen AI adoption plans within their organizations, to prevent potential work knowledge gaps between entry-level and augmented knowledge workers.

CCS Concepts

• **Social and professional topics** → Professional topics; Computing and business; Automation.

Keywords

Generative AI, Future of Work, Knowledge Work, Work Automation, Sustainability

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1 Introduction

The public rollout of ChatGPT in November 2022 heralded the beginning of a new technology adoption wave. Along with the release of several other Generative Artificial Intelligence (“Gen AI”) technologies, both individuals and organizations began to evaluate

the potential usage of Gen AI tools in personal and professional contexts [28]. While these tools are still in their infancy, they have nonetheless made major impacts across various industries, most notably via individual usage within the information and software engineering disciplines [5, 26]. Early research has noted positive results on the workforce from the perspectives of both industry experts and academics, focusing on the productivity benefits of Gen AI tools, specifically related to the automation of routine, repetitive tasks and the augmentation of more complex tasks [25, 27, 31]. As the emphasis on these positive benefits of Gen AI use grows, various large companies and firms across industrial disciplines have publicly noted the desire for their employees to adopt these tools as they roll out Gen-AI based tools increased individual and organizational productivity [2, 29]. However, the requirements and considerations required for the adoption of Gen AI technologies at an organizational level can differ from those for individuals. These organizations must determine a clear vision for the use cases of Gen AI tools, and a plan for both implementation and scaling of these technologies within their organizational structure [15].

While many organizations in the private sector have enthusiastically called for the adoption of Gen AI technologies within their workforce, there have also been many noted concerns from employee-based representation, industry experts, and academics regarding the potential negative effects of large-scale Gen AI adoption [11, 20]. These concerns revolve around the potential of Gen AI technologies to either independently accomplish specific work tasks normally accomplished by a human worker, or in some cases, replace a worker altogether through AI-based automation of their work tasks. [1, 17, 31]. Knowledge-based industries have seen various mass layoffs, restructuring, and reprioritization of new employee hiring and retention in recent years [18, 33]. With this focus on the potential of workforce reduction and replacement through the adoption of Gen AI technology, there is a significant demand of these organizations’ executives and decision-makers to prioritize the adoption of Gen AI tools in ways that can improve productivity while maintaining workers’ well-being [9, 23]. Despite these concerns, many organizations of varying sizes, both public and private, have continued to adopt the use of Gen AI technologies at an increasingly rapid pace [8, 12].

Given the clear concerns over the organizational adoption of Gen AI tools, it becomes necessary to understand how employers, managers, and other executive-level key decision makers (KDM’s) perceive the potential uses of Gen AI by their employees and the resulting impacts on their workforce and industries. Furthermore,



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we must also seek insight into how these KDM's envision the long-term effects of Gen AI adoption within their industries, and any perceived changes to the nature of working roles, along with any potential societal and ethical implications for future workers. Previous studies examine the potential effects to human workers and society, noting that Gen AI use has yielded positive effects on organizational labour productivity [32]. Others have shown potential labour displacement due to Gen AI augmentation and automation, stating the need for new forms of technological governance to avoid significant negative effects on the workforce [14, 22]. However, there are gaps in the research concerning the challenges of organizational adoption, and how KDM's contend with the immediate and long-term ramifications of Gen AI use in the workforce, as these tools shift from being marketed as personal-use software to enterprise-level productivity software [16, 21]. This research seeks to build upon emerging literature, by directly asking KDM's at knowledge work organizations about their views and perceptions of Gen AI adoption by their workers. Specifically, we focus on the following research questions:

- **RQ1:** *How do organizational key decision-makers perceive the usage of generative AI tools to their industry and resulting changes to their workers' roles and responsibilities?*
- **RQ2:** *How do organizational key decision-makers perceive the industrial and societal consequences of generative AI-based work augmentation and/or job automation/replacement?*

Utilizing a qualitative approach, we conducted in-depth interviews with individuals at varying levels of seniority in both public and private organizations, building on emergent literature that seeks to examine organizational perceptions of Gen AI technology adoptions and its potential impact. This study contributes an analysis of KDM perspectives with respect to the use of Gen AI tools and expected transformations to knowledge work within their industries, with recommendations towards responsible Gen AI implementation plans at an organizational level.

2 Extant Literature

Within the industrial field of knowledge work, which can be defined as “the continuous, systematic and predominant expansion of organizational knowledge through the mechanism of exploration” [7], digital automation has been seen as one of the most innovative and transformative new technological approaches, with a focus on enhancing the analytical and decision-making capabilities of human workers [13]. Initially termed as Intelligent Automation (IA), or Cognitive Automation, this newest phase of knowledge work automation has been considered as the latest industrial revolution after the introduction of computers and digital information systems to knowledge-based workplaces [6]. This “Industry 4.0” comprises a more intelligence-focused technological approach, as AI, networked technologies and big data analysis begin to enable some level of task automation [30]. As these approaches become industry-viable work solutions, there has also been growing concern over the capability of these automative tools to accomplish not just routine, non-cognitive tasks, but also non-routine tasks that would typically be considered only achievable by a human worker. Frey and Osborne predict that approximately 47% of office and administrative jobs in the USA could potentially be automated in next

few decades, dramatically impacting knowledge work employment market [10]. Given these persisting concerns of knowledge workers that their roles may be increasingly automated as IA technologies develop [31], academic research has stressed the importance of ethical and sustainable practices on the part of managers and executives as they design and implement IA adoption strategies for themselves and their workers [13, 20].

The rapid advancement of publicly available Gen AI technologies in the last three years has also led to increased adoption of these new tools, with surveys indicating a usage rate of at least 23-25% among both general workers and knowledge workers [4, 5]. Following from past perspectives on IA, knowledge workers still express concerns over both the legitimacy of GenAI outputs, and the potential for these technologies to exacerbate existing issues with worker replacement [1, 20]. It should be noted, however, that studies which investigate knowledge worker perspectives on the increased adoption of Gen AI tools indicated that their participants are not primarily concerned with Gen AI tools causing mass worker replacement. They instead envision Gen AI tools as being able to assist with more complex knowledge-based tasks, though still requiring a human participant [19, 31]. Knowledge workers do maintain a unique set of concerns specific to GenAI tools, centred around the possibility of entry-level job reduction, organizational demands to use GenAI tools, and overreliance on these tools without proper human intervention [31].

While these studies illustrate the importance of understanding worker perspectives when considering the organizational use of Gen AI tools and resulting workplace impacts, there still exists a research gap in extending that understanding to organization executives, managers, and other top-level decision makers. Recent studies have focused on decision makers' perspective on the benefits of Gen AI tools in their own work tasks [3], the importance of including all employees in the decision-making process for organizational AI tool implementation [20], and the need for managers to maintain a level of proactive technological literacy, emphasizing a human-centered approach with considering implementation strategies [13, 24]. This study builds upon the need to understand the current state of KDM knowledge, by focusing on their perspectives specific to the potential impacts of organizational Gen AI tool adoption.

3 Methodology

This study explores the perceptions of knowledge work executives, managers and top-level decision makers, specific to the role of Gen AI in the workplace, with an emphasis on the benefits to employees and the risk of job loss or job automation. Interviews also explored participants' perceptions on job automation in terms of specific roles and industries and their perceptions on the broader societal implications of these technologies both in terms of large benefits and potential risks to large groups of society. Due to the early stage of Gen AI implementation among many organizations in different knowledge sectors, a qualitative approach presents a useful means to develop deep insights in the views and experiences of key stakeholders. Furthermore, the potential changes stemming from Gen AI implementations range from process augmentations to automations and replacement of workers. These changes are likely

Table 1: Participant Demographics

ID	Gender	Organization Size	Industry	Job Level
P1	Male	Large	Education	Executive
P2	Female	Large	Consulting	Manager
P3	Male	Large	Education	Manager
P4	Male	Large	IT	Employee
P5	Male	Large	Software	Employee
P6	Female	SME	Consulting	Employee
P7	Male	SME	Software	Executive
P8	Female	Large	Technology	Manager
P9	Male	Large	Security	Executive
P10	Male	SME	Security	Executive
P11	Female	Large	Education	Executive
P12	Male	Large	Education	Executive
P13	Female	Large	Technology	Manager
P14	Female	SME	Technology	Executive
P15	Male	SME	Technology	Manager
P16	Male	Large	Technology	Employee
P17	Male	SME	Consulting	Executive

to vary also across different knowledge industries and perceptions on organizations' role in these changes are likely to vary depending on the role of the individual. This further serves as justification for adopting qualitative research designs. An interview guide was developed with a combination of open-ended and probing questions to seek participants' views in depth. IRB approval was sought and received from the University.

Participants were recruited using a purposive sampling strategy (Merriam, 2009). Sampling criteria for inclusion were as follows; 1. in-depth knowledge of Gen AI technologies and their potential impacts 2. engaged in implementation of Gen AI technologies in their organization including previous and planned implementations, 3. varied knowledge industries represented including technology, education, security, 4. variety of job levels including executives, managers from low level to middle managers, and employees. In addition, a mix of organization size was targeted. In terms of the level of Gen AI implementation within the organization, again sufficient variety was sought. We followed a similar approach to recent research, namely Haefner et al. (2023) and included organizations are different stages of Gen AI implementation from planning to scaling.

Prior to the interviews, each participant was provided with an overview of the study's aims, transcription procedures, and processes in place to protect the confidentiality of participant data. All participants were afforded the opportunity to discuss any concerns beforehand. Written consent was obtained from participants to allow the recording and transcription of the interview, as well as the use of anonymized quotes. All interviews were conducted virtually via Zoom at a time of the participant's choosing. The interviews lasted an average of 32 minutes. Transcription was initially completed by Zoom and then reviewed by the research team. Each transcript was then reviewed along the audio/video to correct all transcription errors. During the transcription process, repeat words were also removed.

All data was open-coded by the research team with an inductive approach pursued (Spiggle, 1994). Following the interviews with the first 14 respondents, the analysis from the subsequent 3 respondents largely complemented and supplemented existing analysis rather than suggesting new themes and codes suggesting 'theoretical saturation' was reached (Glaser and Strauss, 2009). The sample consisted of 17 participants (11 male, 6 female), the details of which are outlined below in Table 1. The sample size also aligns with widely acceptable sample size for interview studies (e.g. Rowlands et al., 2016). As shown in Table 1, participants are from both large organizations (n=11) and SMEs (n=6) and varied in terms of the industries and roles they represented. Across the industries several sectors were represented such as software and hardware, technology consulting, and privacy consulting. A sufficient variety in job level was also achieved with executives (n=8), managers (n=5), and employees (n=4) all included. This allows for rich mix of insights across organization size, industry, and job level.

4 Findings

4.1 Uses for Gen AI Tools and Changes to Worker Roles and Responsibilities

Interview participants gave a variety of answers toward worker usage of Gen AI tools within their respective industries, centered around improving the work efficiency of routine knowledge retrieval and knowledge synthesis tasks. P2, a sales director at a large consulting firm, described how their "*general counsel are using Gen AI to review master services agreements so that they don't have to do as much. We're just kind of approaching all of these different areas and seeing how we can save time and reduce complexity.*" However, participant answers lacked specificity to specific current changes in worker behaviors, instead focusing on the potential long-term transformative potential of Gen AI tools on workers' day-to-day tasks and responsibilities. For example, P9, the CEO of a Security

SME, stated of software engineering that *“I think soon learning different programming languages will become a moot point and it’s more of interacting with LLMs and architecting things at a very high level...you’re just English language prompting and code is coming out”*.

Several participants (P3, P7, P12, P13, P14) expressed their belief that the advent of Gen AI tools would become revolutionary to their industries, completely changing how workers perform their tasks and the scope of their responsibilities. To that end, participants articulated an urgent need for knowledge workers to adopt the use of Gen AI tools, indicating that these workers would be considered more competitive than those that refused to use Gen AI tools: *“We do think Gen AI is a permanent part of the workplace. But AI is not coming for your job. The person who knows how to use AI is coming for your job.”* (P3). They expressed that Gen AI tools would be inevitable mass addition to the workplace, and therefore workers would have no choice but to learn how to use these new tools or risk their job security being exposed to workers who would be more open to the use of Gen AI tools into their work. As P1 stated, *“...If you’re good at an A, B-, B+ level and then suddenly a C- developer with the help of augmented tools, becomes a B level. Aren’t you by extension, hurting yourself by not also using the same tool set?”*. Participants also noted that their children and the next generation of future knowledge workers would have to be experienced in the use of Gen AI tools to be competitive in the job market, with P3 expressing that *“My gut feeling is that students will migrate towards majors that will be AI proof”*.

4.2 Industrial and Societal Consequences of Gen AI-based Work Augmentation/Automation

With respect to work augmentation, some participants (P3, P4, P7, P15) maintained the idea of Gen AI tools as strictly assistive, and that it was very unlikely that they would replace workers completely, at least in the short term. However, the most common theme across participant responses was an anticipation in the short-term of worker team size reduction through Gen AI augmentation, as improved efficiency would allow fewer workers to accomplish a similar amount of work: *“But I do think in 10 years you’ll see the population of software developers is going to be very, very small. Or a lot smaller than it is today. And I think they’ll operate differently, at a more abstract level”* (P10). While participants still expressed the importance of a human worker to ensure the rigor and quality of Gen AI outputs (P7), the long-term outlook of many still focused on an eventual shift from augmentation-based Gen AI use to cases of worker reduction, especially as tools become more sophisticated over time. P2 suggested that large tech companies like Microsoft and Facebook were pursuing aggressive layoff strategies as a result of these Gen AI-based productivity gains, though P9 was more skeptical: *“There’s always the downside of like workforce reduction, right? Because you get productivity increases...but in the short term there’s some impact on team sizes. I think we’re seeing a lot of reduction in tech. I don’t know if that’s actually directly correlated to this. So far, I think that’s just an economic cycle.”*

Finally, with respect to societal changes as a result of Gen AI adoption in knowledge work, participants raised a few key issues. P7 noted that because of Gen AI automation of certain tasks, the

barrier of entry to high-skill knowledge work could be reduced, such as programming becoming a less specialized field that subject-matter experts in other fields could perform through Gen AI tools. However, P15 expressed a concern that while Gen AI use would allow for workers to focus on higher-level tasks, entry-level work roles could face the most risk for job and opportunity reduction. Indeed, a common thread throughout participant responses (P9, P15) was the idea of workers approaching a new cognitive shift towards higher-level tasks, as day-to-day work becomes more efficient and/or automated through Gen AI tool usage: *“I see this as if you can effectively use the tool, then it can help you do your job faster and allow you to move on to other things with your job, and maybe get into some of the higher level tasks that are involved with whatever your role entails”* (P15). However, with a reduction in entry-level work and the concept of workers shifting towards higher-order tasks, P8 expressed concern over a growing digital job divide, as learning opportunities for new workers are reduced while current knowledge workers are pushed for task automation: *“We’re actually removing the main basis of learning opportunities for so many careers and people...So these people are going to do higher level jobs based on what experience?”* (P8)

5 Discussion and Conclusion

In this study, we found a wide variety of perspectives on how KDM’s view the use of Gen AI tools within their organizations and resulting consequences. We realized that while many KDM’s were quite enthusiastic about worker adoption of Gen AI tools, they were often unable to articulate more specific benefits about the long-term transformative potential of Gen AI. KDM’s largely share a similar perspective with knowledge workers in that Gen AI tools should augment work without increasing the risk of their entire role becoming automated [31]. However, they tend to describe the advent of Gen AI tools as an inevitable revolution in how knowledge work will be accomplished, while defaulting to arbitrary explanations for how these transformations will occur. Of particular interest is the fact that the majority of participants at the executive job level spoke frequently about the potential of job replacement or workforce reduction, either through workers more experienced in using Gen AI tools, or team size reduction due to productivity gains. This stands in contrast to those at the managerial level, who more often adopted the stance of augmentation without replacement. This potential disconnect between employee/managerial and executive-level individuals reinforces the importance of corporate social responsibility in the design and implementation of Gen AI adoption plans within knowledge work organizations and companies [13].

While our KDM’s were somewhat unsure of the short-term localized impacts of Gen AI adoption within their organizations, there was a much clearer outlook on the future of work and employment across the knowledge industry, focused on the necessity for new workers to be well-versed and experienced in the use of Gen AI tools. Despite this clarity, obvious concern persists over the potential widening gap between reduction of entry-level work opportunities and the idea of current workers’ eventual low-level task automation. This work-training gap presents a unique opportunity for KDM’s to set a balance between the degree to which routine and

low-level work tasks are automated within their organizations, and the expectations of entry-level roles' job training, so that new workers are able to sufficiently learn how the importance and reasoning behind specific low-level tasks, before being allowed to use Gen AI tools for increased efficiency and automation. Similarly, while the idea of workers automating non-cognitive tasks has been studied within the realm of intelligent automation [30], KDM's must take care in assuming that workers will naturally shift towards higher-order knowledge work where they might be expected to make creative or concept-level decisions. We suggest that KDM's collaborate more closely with workers to determine any specific changes in their roles and responsibilities. If increased productivity and task automation is expected to move workers towards higher-order tasks and goals. A co-operatively designed Gen AI implementation plan may serve to prevent a work knowledge gap, especially at a time of mass layoffs within the technology and knowledge works sectors worldwide.

While our work explores a snapshot of varied KDM perspectives with respect to the organizational use of Gen AI tools, we were limited in not being able to comprehensively compare these perspectives to the details of any conceptual or in-progress Gen AI implementation plan within their organizations. Future work may take a longitudinal approach, considering the perspectives and experiences of both KDM's and workers as the use of Gen AI tools becomes more prevalent and encouraged for day-to-day task augmentation and automation. Furthermore, studying the potential for overreliance on Gen AI tools should be considered, especially due to the seemingly volatile nature of Gen AI development and investment by large technology companies. While workers are currently being encouraged to increase their usage of Gen AI tools, future research may seek an understanding of how much workers rely on Gen AI tools in their daily tasks, and potential disruptions in the case of losing access to these tools, either temporarily or permanently.

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